

The 64-bit itch

64-bit computing for consumers is now several steps closer to fruition. The contenders are: The x86-64 solutions from AMD, i.e., the server chip, Opteron, and the desktop chip, AMD 64, an x86-64 Intel Pentium 4-based Prescott chip for the desktop, and IBM's PowerPC 970FX for Apple-based solutions.

The IBM solution won the Microprocessor Report Analyst's Choice Award for Best Desktop Processor. It is a 90-nm, but unlike the Intel processor, it consumes far less power. IBM claims that the 970FX draws about 25 W running generic applications at a speed of 2.0 GHz—50 per cent lesser than the PowerPC chip that powers the Apple G5. Compare this to Pentium 4 3.00E (the Prescott), which puts out 89 W of heat and the efficiency becomes apparent.

The Pentium 4 CPUs, with 1 MB L2 cache on the 90 nm process, will be tweaked to improve its power rating. At the Intel Developer Forum, February 2004, Craig Barrett of Intel confirmed that Nocona, its next generation of server processors—Xeons and desktop Prescotts will both get 64-bit extensions later this year. Supporting the move is Microsoft's OS-level support: A beta version of Windows XP for the x86-64 is already doing the rounds.

snapshot

Google currently indexes over **6 billion documents; 4,28,51,99,774 of which are Web pages**

Source: Google, Inc

Linux shining

After a personal nod from President A. P. J. Kalam Azad, Linux and the open-source movement made further inroads into India. Seven government and private institutes plan to use Linux to run Oracle applications, the company recently announced. "2004 will be the year of Linux in India," Shekhar Dasgupta, Managing Director of Oracle India, said in a statement. "We see the banking, government and education sectors leading the adoption of Linux to run mission-critical applications."

The agencies benefitting from this move include the state-owned Central Bank of India, Bharat Sanchar Nigam Ltd, the treasury department of West Bengal and two private banks. Indian Railway Catering Services and Tourism said it has chosen Red Hat Linux to work with Oracle's e-business suite. Linux will allow for a 30 per cent saving in IT expenses—about Rs 180 million per year.

The major attraction for

government and large organizations towards Linux is two-fold: price is obviously a factor, although not a large one, since supporting an operating system is a factor that needs to be considered; the honey-pot is the fact that the source-code of the Linux kernel and its supporting cast is freely and publicly available for scrutiny and modification. This is

a huge boost to institutes where paranoia is a positive trait, and security is paramount.

To counter this mindset, Microsoft recently announced its intent to share the source-code of its Windows family of operating systems with Asian governments and institutes. Indeed, after the success that Linux was enjoying in the Thai marketplace, Microsoft began offering Thai citizens a bundle of Microsoft Windows XP Home and Office XP Standard. Platform-jumping is a rare event in both a consumer's and a businesses' life-cycle; Microsoft obviously wants to capture upcoming markets before Linux gets a toe-hold.



Enterprise shutterbugs, only

Canon India recently set up India's first two Digital Imaging Solutions Laboratories for enterprise users in New Delhi and Bangalore. The lab is going to be a testing ground to try out new innovations and ideas for businesses of all sorts. It will simulate real business environments and allow their cus-

tomers to inspect, test and try out proposed ideas and solutions in the fields of document management, transaction printing, and colour applications for offices and enterprises. This can be done at minimal costs. Canon claims to have spent Rs 60 crores on the lab, and has expansion plans in mind.



Spam

Now it's IM's turn

Spam over the Instant Messaging (IM) or SPIM is not a big problem now because the username list for IM clients as well as the tools to mass message are not commonly available.

Yahoo! has already taken measures to prevent misuse. First, while registering, you have to go through an image-verification test that automated systems cannot pass. It also blocks users who send unusually high number of messages.

Microsoft also lets you see the list of people who have added you on their list in its new version (6.1). You can choose to block messages.

Dragooning spam

The Chinese government is taking the problem of spam seriously and is fighting hard against it. Recently, the Ministries of Public Security, Education and Information announced an anti-spam campaign that also targets reactionary spam. 'Reactionary' is a political term used for individuals and content considered to be threats to the Chinese government.

In February this year, the Internet Society of China (ISC) identified 626 servers, including 68 in China and 6 in Hong Kong as sources of spam. ISC said that they have taken some measures such as getting e-mail providers to adopt anti-spam technologies. However, many Chinese servers are working as spam relays due to the rapid Internet expansion. Thus, those run by China Telecom and China Netcom Communication Group have also been blacklisted as spam relays.



■ Adobe server software to help restrict access to electronic documents in workplaces ■ StreamCast Networks to unfurl low cost Net telephony service